General Faculties Council
Graduate Academic Program Subcommittee
Approved Minutes

Wednesday, January 22, 2025, 10:00 a.m.
Meeting #89 A167/Zoom

Voting Members
Qiao Sun, Academic Co-Chair
Getachew Assefa*
Amy Dambrowitz
Jessalynn Keller*
Kimberly Lenters
Elizabeth Oddone Paolucci*
Oleksiy Osiyevskyy
Alexandria Poppendorf

Non-Voting Members
Christine Johns
Louise Wells*
Michael Wright*

Meeting Secretary
Michelle Speta

Scribe
Vanessa Kozielec

Regrets
Tara Beattie, Co-Chair
Justin MacCallum
Catherine McLeod

Guests
Jenny Godley, Associate Dean, Transdisciplinary Scholarship, Faculty of Graduate Studies
– present for Item 3
Heather Jamniczky, Associate Dean, Graduate Science Education, Cumming School of Medicine
– present for Item 4
Rahim Kachra*, Medical Director, Master of Physician Assistant Studies Program, Cumming School of Medicine
– present for Item 4
Lisa Welikovitch*, Senior Associate Dean, Education, Cumming School of Medicine
– present for Item 4
Chenwei Lian*, Program Manager, Master of Physician Assistant Studies, Cumming School of Medicine
– present for Item 4
Mindi Summers, Associate Dean, Undergraduate Programs and Student Affairs, Faculty of Science
– present for Item 5
Lies Thompson, Manager, Graduate Science Centre, Faculty of Science
– present for Item 5

**Attended virtually*

Secretary's Note: In accordance with the General Faculties Council (GFC) Bylaws Section 8.2, the motion box and "Carried" denotation serves as the entry in the minutes that the Chair of the meeting declared the motion carried.

The Chair called the meeting to order at 10:02 a.m. and confirmed quorum.

1. Meeting Opening

1.1. Approval of the Agenda

Moved/Seconded

That the Agenda for the January 22, 2025 Graduate Academic Program Subcommittee meeting be approved.

Carried

1.2. Traditional Land Acknowledgement

The Co-Chair provided a Traditional Land Acknowledgement.

1.3. Remarks of the Co-Chair

Amy Dambrowitz, Registrar, provided an update on Provincial Attestation Letter (PAL) allocations, including that:

- The federal government has clarified that international Master's and doctoral level students are required to obtain a PAL to apply for a study permit. Originally, it was hoped that graduate level students would be exempt from needing PALs.
- The University has not yet received its 2025 PAL allocation, but it is expected that 16% of PALs allocated to the University of Calgary will be reserved exclusively for Master's and doctoral students. The remaining 84% can be issued to undergraduate students or graduate students of all levels.
- In 2024, the University saw international student applications drop by approximately 40% as a result of the student visa/PAL process. As a result, the University was not able to use up its 2024 allocation of PALs. Discussions are ongoing at various levels within the University on supporting international student recruitment in light of these challenges.

2. Approval of the December 11, 2024 Meeting Minutes

Documentation was circulated with the Agenda.

Moved/Seconded

That the Minutes of the Graduate Academic Program Subcommittee meeting held on December 11, 2024 be approved.

Carried

3. Revisions to the Calendar Entries for the Master of Transdisciplinary Research, the Doctor of Philosophy (PhD) in Transdisciplinary Research, and the Graduate Certificate in Transdisciplinary Studies I

Documentation was circulated with the Agenda. Jenny Godley, Associate Dean (Transdisciplinary Scholarship), Faculty of Graduate Studies, presented this item.

Highlights:

- The presenter provided an overview of the proposed revisions to the Calendar entries for the Master of Transdisciplinary Research (MTR), the Doctor of Philosophy (PhD) in Transdisciplinary Research, and the Graduate Certificate in Transdisciplinary Studies I, in preparation for the Fall 2025 program launch.
- The proposed change for the thesis-based programs is the removal of specific course lists for each specialization in the MTR and PhD programs. Instead, required courses will be determined through consultation between the student and their supervisor(s), and approved by the supervisory committee.
- The proposed change for the Graduate Certificate is the addition of admission requirements and courses for the new specialization in Social Innovation.
- In response to questions, it was explained that:
    - The Social Research Methods specialization is taught through the Sociology graduate program in the Faculty of Arts, which is why its courses carry the "SOCI" course code. The Social Innovation specialization is taught through both the Faculty of Nursing and the Cumming School of Medicine.
    - Advanced credit will not normally be permitted because the certificates are designed as cumulative learning experiences, where courses build on each other. As a result, even if a student has taken a similar course at another institution, it may not align with the full certificate structure. Changes to this rule may be considered in the future with further development of transdisciplinary programming (e.g., micro-credentials).
- The presenter reported an amendment to add course codes for the four new Social Innovation specialization courses in the Graduate Certificate in Transdisciplinary Studies I. The presenter explained that code "SOIN" would be used for courses taught by the Faculty of Nursing (Social Innovation 601 and 605) and "SOIM" would be used for courses taught by the Cumming School of Medicine (Social Innovation 603 and 607).
- It was noted that the proposed course codes had not yet been reviewed by the Office of the Registrar. The Committee directed that approval of the reported amendment is contingent upon the Registrar's approval of the course codes.
- The Committee also directed that consultation with the Sociology Graduate Program be undertaken regarding the work experience requirement for admission to the Social Research Methods specialization. To ensure this is not a barrier for applicants, revised wording to clarify what would be considered applicable towards this requirement (e.g., volunteer or internship experience) should also be considered.

Moved/Seconded

That the Graduate Academic Program Subcommittee (GAPS) approve the proposed revisions to the Calendar entries for the Master of Transdisciplinary Research, the Doctor of Philosophy (PhD) in Transdisciplinary Research, and the Graduate Certificate in Transdisciplinary Studies I, effective for the 2024-2025 Calendar, as recommended by the GAPS Calendar Working Group and as set out in the documents provided, with the reported amendment, subject to the approval of the Office of the Registrar.

Carried

4. <u>Approval of the Cumming School of Medicine 2025-2026 Graduate Program Calendar Revisions</u>

Documentation was circulated with the Agenda. Heather Jamniczky, Associate Dean (Graduate Science Education), Rahim Kachra, Medical Director, Master of Physician Assistant Studies (MPAS) Program, Lisa Welikovitch, Associate Dean (Education), and Chenwei Lian, MPAS Program Manager, all from the Cumming

School of Medicine, presented this item.

Highlights:

- The presenters provided an overview of the proposed revisions to the graduate programs and courses administered through the Graduate Science Education Office in the Cumming School of Medicine (CSM). Substantive changes included the addition of a direct-entry, full-time pathway for the Master of Precision Health, clarifying course requirements for the Master of Science (MSc) and PhD in Neuroscience programs, and updating courses in the Precision Health, Community Health Sciences, Medical Science, and the Master of Pathologists' Assistant programs.
- The presenters also reviewed the changes to the Master of Physician Assistant Studies (MPAS) program, which include:
    - No longer accepting applications from fourth-year students effective Fall 2025. Rationales for this change include the administrative delays caused by the need to wait for final grades for these applicants, and ensuring that all applicants have sufficient clinical experience for success in the program.
    - Adjusting Year Two courses to a more standardized scheduling model (all core clinical rotation courses adjusted to 160 hours, 3 units, and selective rotation courses adjusted to 80 hours, 3 units) for better alignment with the Undergraduate Medical Education (UME) and Postgraduate Medical Education (PGME) units. These updates will not affect the total number of units required for students to complete the MPAS program, and the overall program structure remains unchanged.
- The presenters reported an amendment to the title of the Obstetrics and Gynecology rotation course, MDPS 648 "Low Risk Obstetrics and Gynecology" to strike "Low Risk." The course title change reflects that the Department of Obstetrics and Gynecology has the capacity to provide full clinical rotations in this area for MPAS. The Committee had no concerns with this change.
- In response to questions, it was explained that:
    - Community Health Sciences (MDCH) and Medical Science (MDSC) 613.01 are cross-listed courses offered at the same time by the same instructor. The duplicate course listings reflect the fact that students come from two different programs, therefore two different sets of pre-requisites may be appropriate.
    - For MPAS Year Two courses, the changes to re-numbering and program length will remain within the parameters set-out by the Registrar's Office and the academic terms of the institution.
    - Last year, 5-7% of applicants were students in their final year of undergraduate studies, and none were admitted. As such, there were no observed performance issues in the program for students entering directly from a Bachelor's degree, but practical work experience in the medical field and the maturity that comes with that experience are critical for success in the MPAS program.
    - Comparable programs offered at the University of Manitoba and University of Saskatchewan do permit conditional admissions for fourth-year students, but also have different program structures and hours than the CSM's program. Losing applicants to other institutions because of this change is not of concern as MPAS had a less than 10% acceptance rate last year.
    - A minimum number of clinical experience hours requirement for admission is not being considered at this time because there have not been enough cohorts of students who have gone through the program to effectively determine a threshold. This will be re-evaluated after the program has been running for three to four years.
- The Committee expressed concerns regarding the MPAS admission change. The discussion included:

  - The Fall 2025 application cycle is nearly complete. Late-stage changes to the admission cycle are only made in cases where the change is beneficial to students. Fall 2026 is the earliest that a change like this should be implemented to allow adequate time for communication to prospective students.
  - Fourth-year students may have clinical experience from professional work undertaken prior to commencing their studies. The major concern is whether an applicant has enough clinical experience, rather than whether they are applying to the program before completing the Bachelor's degree in which they are currently enrolled.
- The Committee did not support the change to exclude fourth-year students from applying to the MPAS program and recommended that the proponents work with the Faculty of Graduate Studies and Office of the Registrar to develop any changes to admission regulations that address the matter of ensuring applicants have enough clinical experience effective for Fall 2026.

Moved/Seconded

That the Graduate Academic approve the proposed Calendar revisions for graduate programs in the Cumming School of Medicine, except for the change to admission requirements for the Master of Physician Assistant Studies (MPAS) program, effective for the 2025-2026 Calendar, as recommended by the GAPS Calendar Working Group and as set out in the documents provided.

Carried

5. Approval of the Faculty of Science Additional 2024-2025 and 2025-2026 Graduate Program Calendar Revisions

Documentation was circulated with the Agenda. From the Faculty of Science, Mindi Summers, Associate Dean, Undergraduate Programs and Student Affairs, and Lies Thompson, Manager, Graduate Science Centre, presented this item.

Highlights:

- The presenters provided an overview of the proposed Calendar revisions for graduate professional programs in the Faculty of Science, as well as the new course entry for Physics (PHYS) 622: Physics Quantum Computing Essentials.
- The presenters explained that the PHYS 622 course is being requested for the 2024-2025 Calendar because it needed to be timetabled for Spring 2025. This course is a requirement in the iQuCode CREATE program for MSc and PhD students in Physics and Astronomy.
- Substantive changes to the professional program Calendar entries include clarification that the laddered pathway programs can be completed either full-time or part-time, while the direct-entry Master's requires full-time registration status. Allowing part-time status for the laddered pathway adds flexibility, recognizing that many students in this professional program are likely employed while completing their studies.
- The Committee's discussion included:
  - Language regarding laddering credit, and whether it is clear that students who complete a credential in the laddered pathway earn credit for that credential even if they do not continue to the next credential. It was noted that "laddering credit" is a defined term independent of "credit." The Committee suggested that hyperlinks be added to Calendar entries for "laddering credit" to clarify this.

- The flexible grade option (Credit Granted, CG) allows students who successfully complete a course to opt for the CG grade instead of the letter grade they earned. This option is intended to encourage students to take courses outside of their program without negatively impacting their GPA. Individual programs have the autonomy to decide whether to accept CG grades across all courses or only for certain courses.
- There are PeopleSoft system limitations with regards to pre-requisites on non-standard courses whereby one non-standard course cannot be a pre-requisite for another.

- The Committee directed that the language used for the Flexible Grade Option for each program be reviewed to ensure the alignment with the intended meaning. For example, the Data Science and Analytics program's policy, as written, is that CG impacts eligibility for awards. If the intended meaning is that eligibility for awards is in fact impacted, revision of the language will be required.
- The Committee also directed that the non-standard courses and their pre-requisites be reviewed with the Registrar's Office as soon as possible to ensure that the courses are able to be systematized, as outlined.

Moved/Seconded

That the Graduate Academic Program Subcommittee (GAPS) approve the proposed Calendar revisions for graduate professional programs in the Faculty of Science, effective for the 2025-2026 Calendar, as recommended by the GAPS Calendar Working Group and as set out in the documents provided.

Carried

Moved/Seconded

That the Graduate Academic Program Subcommittee approve the Calendar entry for the new course Physics 622: Physics Quantum Computing Essentials in the Faculty of Science, effective for the 2024-2025 Calendar, as set out in the documents provided.

Carried

6. Faculty of Graduate Studies' Artificial Intelligence Guidelines

Documentation was circulated with the Agenda. Oleksiy Osiyevskyy, Associate Dean (Policy and Program Development), Faculty of Graduate Studies, presented this item.

Highlights:

- The presenter provided an overview of the proposed Faculty of Graduate Studies (FGS) Artificial Intelligence (AI) Guidelines.
- The presenter explained that the increasing use of AI in graduate studies is raising concerns across the Faculties, particularly regarding its role in candidacy components, dissertations, and research.
- The Guidelines for Generative AI Use in Graduate Studies were developed based on a report from the Western Canadian Deans of Graduate Studies that outline best practices for universities to consider when navigating regulations for Generative AI (GenAI) use. Official University-level policies have not yet been established; the FGS' Guidelines serve as recommendations and will require continuous updates as policies evolve.
- The Guidelines aim to help students understand how, when, and if they can use GenAI in their academic work, as well as the role of supervisors in permitting or restricting its use. Given that GenAI literacy is

expected to be a critical skill for future employment, it is important that students learn how to use GenAI properly if its use is permitted. The Guidelines outline five guiding principles: (1) Authorized Use: GenAI tools must be authorized by a supervisor for editing or proofreading, (2) Transparent Use: GenAI use must be transparent and declared, (3) Accountability and Authorship: Students remain fully accountable for their work, even if AI-generated content is referenced, (4) Privacy and Data Security must be maintained, and (5) Ethical Considerations: Students must be aware of ethical considerations, including potential biases in AI tools.

- The Guidelines are currently available on the FGS website. The next step is to collaborate with Libraries and Cultural Resources to integrate the Guidelines into the Academic Integrity resource library.
- In response to questions, it was explained that as the Guidelines evolve, there is an expectation that graduate supervisors will become familiar with GenAI tools and encourage their appropriate use. Since GenAI use is inherently linked to ethical considerations, it is already within the scope of their supervisory role. Discussions are ongoing regarding how to best support and train supervisors to take on this responsibility effectively.

7. Program Approvals Status Report

Documentation was circulated with the Agenda for information only. Questions can be directed to the Program Innovation Hub.

8. Other Business

There was no other business.

9. Adjournment

Moved/Seconded

That the Graduate Academic Program Subcommittee adjourn the January 22, 2025 meeting.

Carried

The meeting was adjourned at 11:55 a.m.

Michelle Speta
Associate Secretary